

SIPRA DAS



▲ **RAMBIR MIGRANT FROM SHANJAHANPUR, UTTAR PRADESH**
He was brutally murdered and his body was dumped on the Panipat-Jind railway line. A case has been registered but the culprits are yet to be tracked.

"We have lost our sole bread-earner and will gain nothing from the court case."
RAMESHWARI, MOTHER

these unidentified bodies could be those of the victims of inter-state contract killers is not exaggerated and has, in fact, been lent credence by mounting evidence. Take, for example, the case of Chander Shekhar, a migrant from Bulandshahar in Uttar Pradesh. The only son of poor parents was strangulated and his body was thrown on the tracks near Faridabad on May 15 last year. The body, however, was identified by his family and a post-mortem confirmed it to be a case of murder. On the basis of family's tip-off, the GRP cracked the case and arrested Raj Kumar of Bulandshahar, who had paid Rs 20,000 to one Sanjiv Kumar for carrying out the murder. Sanjiv has been arrested as well. Raj Kumar had a financial dispute with the victim and had paid a 'supari' to

get him eliminated.

Only a few such cases ever reach the court, while others are labelled "untraced" after going through the formality of investigations against unknown accused. Parladh Singh, a 40-year-old sweet maker of village Jassi Bagh Wali on the Punjab-Haryana border, was found dead on the railway tracks on September 5 last year. Initially concluded to be an accident or a suicide case, a blood trail and signs of struggle on the sides of track aroused the family's suspicion and a post-mortem report confirmed that he had been murdered. Two months later, the police cracked the case and arrested three villagers, Gurpreet Singh, Meena and Harpal Singh, who later confessed their crime. "But for our insistence, the murderers would have gone scot-free," rues the victim's widow Harpal Kaur.

Not surprisingly, unidentified bodies on the tracks have become a major concern of the police authorities. Last month, Haryana DGP Ranjiv Dalal shot off a letter to the Railway authorities, suggesting track surveillance through installation of cameras in front of the engines to record the sequence of events leading to a person's death on the rail track. "Many-a-times, such incidents become controversial and create serious law and order problems for the Haryana Police," the letter says. Dalal says he was forced to take such a step in the wake of a huge outcry over the death of two college-going sisters, Manju, 18, and Mithilesh, 17, of Prithala village, whose mutilated bodies were recovered from the railway tracks near Ballabhgarh in Faridabad district on December 18 last year. While the police investigations concluded the cases to be of suicide, forensic examinations by the Post-Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research at Rohtak showed that they were raped, fuelling allegations that both were murdered first and then thrown on the tracks. In the face of public ire and charges of attempts to shield

the accused by certain influential Congressmen, the state Government has ordered a CBI probe into the incident.

Clearly, there is more than what meets the eye in spiralling cases of unidentified bodies. Only a deeper investigation could probably unravel the murky truth of the mystery and motives behind the bloody rail tracks. ■

VULNERABLE

Most victims are said to be migrant labourers from Bihar who go to Punjab and Haryana during the harvest season to eke out a living.